

FLAGSHIP ANNUAL REPORT

The State of Arts Funding 2026

BFTA's annual anchor document on public, private, and non-state-dependent funding of the arts in the United States, with the global research mandate as backdrop. The report establishes the funding landscape, documents the collapse of 2024–2026, traces who is hurt first, summarizes the market response from foundations and individual donors, and concludes with the analytical case for non-state-dependent funding.

Byline

Bitcoin for the Arts Research

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6.6%

ARTS GDP GROWTH

Real arts and cultural economic activity growth in 2023, compared with 2.9% real GDP growth for the broader U.S. economy. ^[1]

\$1.17T

GDP CONTRIBUTION

Arts and cultural economic activity accounted for 4.2% of U.S. GDP in 2023. ^[1]

5.4M

ARTS EMPLOYMENT

Arts and cultural employment nationwide in 2023. ^[1]

-7.7%

STATE ARTS FUNDING

Projected FY2026 decline in total state and jurisdictional arts agency appropriations. ^[3]

Abstract

BFTA's annual anchor document on public, private, and non-state-dependent funding of the arts in the United States, with the global research mandate as backdrop. The report establishes the funding landscape, documents the collapse of 2024–2026, traces who is hurt first, summarizes the market response from foundations and individual donors, and concludes with the analytical case for non-state-dependent funding.

WHY THIS BRIEF EXISTS

Bitcoin for the Arts Research is the public research program of Bitcoin For The Arts, Inc., a 501(c)(3) nonprofit. Every claim in this document is traceable to a primary source. The institutional byline is "Bitcoin for the Arts Research" — there are no personal bylines on BFTA reports. See the live web version for the full report; this PDF is the citable, print-ready brief.

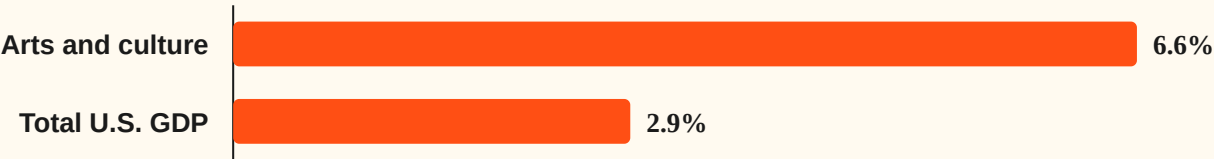
Report structure

01	Executive summary
02	The funding landscape today
03	The collapse: 2024–2026
04	Who gets hurt
05	The market response
06	The case for non-state-dependent funding

Headline charts

Arts sector growth compared with the broader U.S. economy

Real 2023 growth: arts and cultural economic activity grew more than twice as fast as real GDP.



Source: U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis, Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account, U.S. and States, 2023.

State arts agency appropriations are projected to decline in FY2026

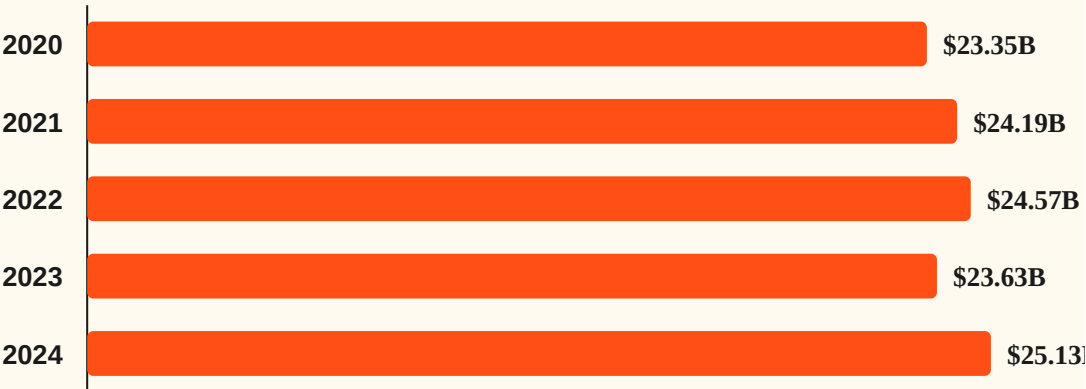
NASAA's preliminary FY2026 preview shows total state and jurisdictional arts agency appropriations falling from roughly \$704.2M to \$650.2M.



Source: National Assembly of State Arts Agencies, FY2026 legislative appropriations preview.

Private giving to arts, culture, and humanities recovered in 2024

Giving USA reported inflation-adjusted giving to arts, culture, and humanities at \$25.13B in 2024, an all-time high for the subsector.



Source: Giving USA 2025, researched by Indiana University Lilly Family School of Philanthropy.

Where to read the full report

The complete, web-rendered version of this report — with full narrative text, source-linked footnotes, and any updates posted since this PDF was generated — lives at bitcoinforthearts.org/research/state-of-arts-funding-2026. The canonical, citable chart-data JSON behind every number in this brief is published at github.com/Bitcoin-For-The-Arts/Research.

"If we do not have a reference, we do not publish the data. Period." — BFTA Research methodology

References

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- [2] National Endowment for the Arts, Arts and Cultural Industries Grew at Twice the Rate of the U.S. Economy. <https://www.arts.gov/news/press-releases/2025/arts-and-cultural-industries-grew-twice-rate-us-economy-adding-12-trillion>
- [3] National Assembly of State Arts Agencies, FY2026 legislative appropriations preview. <https://nasaa-arts.org/communication/state-arts-agency-fy2026-legislative-appropriations-preview/>
- [4] U.S. Department of the Treasury, State and Local Fiscal Recovery Funds. <https://home.treasury.gov/policy-issues/coronavirus/assistance-for-state-local-and-tribal-governments/state-and-local-fiscal-recovery-funds>
- [5] National Assembly of State Arts Agencies, President's FY2026 Budget Cuts NEA. <https://nasaa-arts.org/newsletter/2025-nasaa-notes-issues/may-2025-nasaa-notes/presidents-fy2026-budget-cuts-nea/>
- [6] National Endowment for the Arts, Updates on FY 2026 Grant Opportunities. <https://www.arts.gov/news/press-releases/2025/updates-national-endowment-arts-fy-2026-grant-opportunities>
- [7] Americans for the Arts, Arts & Economic Prosperity 6 Study Findings. <https://aep6.americansforthearts.org/study-findings>
- [8] Giving USA 2025, researched by Indiana University Lilly Family School of Philanthropy. https://philanthropy.iupui.edu/news-events/news/_news/2025/giving-usa-2025.html
- [9] KPBS, San Diego Mayor's proposed budget slashes arts and culture funding. <https://www.kpbs.org/news/arts-culture/2026/04/20/san-diego-mayors-proposed-budget-slashes-arts-and-culture-funding>

About this brief. This PDF is generated from `data/reports/state-of-arts-funding-2026.json` in the public research repository at github.com/Bitcoin-For-The-Arts/Research using the build script `scripts/build-pdfs.mjs`. Every figure shown in this brief is derived from the same JSON dataset and the primary sources listed above. Corrections and source updates may be submitted at github.com/Bitcoin-For-The-Arts/Research/issues or by emailing info@bitcoinforthearts.org.

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